



ALLEYES ON

The recently concluded Meghalaya Games **underscores the effort** of the state to break its conventional image and emerge as a formidable power in sports in North East India.

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The hill-locked state of Meghalaya is on the move and it is earnestly trying to come out of the stereotyped image and perceived notion of being a one-sport, football-crazy state.

True, football is still the most popular sport in the state, and Shillong Lajong FC and its vibrant supporters have been the face of Meghalaya sports for quite sometime.

But it may no longer be the same given the frantic pace at which the Meghalaya State Government, under Conrad K. Sangma, is promoting sports and building infrastructure in the state.

The need to build a solid sports eco-system rose after the continued poor show in multi-discipline events like the National Games and Khelo India Games.

The State Government, along with Meghalaya State Olympic Association (MSOA), has tied up with Edge 10, a sports firm run by former Australian Olympians — Ian Champbell and Robert Kabbas, to identify and nurture talent.

The scheme has been running in the state for the last two years and has brought in some positive results with some sportspersons attached to the scheme winning medals in the recently concluded Meghalaya Games.

The fifth Meghalaya Games, which was held in Tura recently, was an important milestone in the history of the state. For the first time ever, the multi-discipline event was held away from the capital city of Shillong. In many ways, it was a dress rehearsal for the preparedness of the district to hold some events of the 40th National Games, which has been allotted to the state.

Around 3000 athletes and a huge number of officials descended on this quaint town — which is the district headquarters of West Garo Hills. For a week the town was a beehive of activity, and its organisational, hospitality and logistical abilities to conduct a multi-discipline event were tested.

But the district administration, with the help of 1500 volunteers, was able to conduct the Games smoothly, without any complaints. The State Government sanctioned ₹23 crore to cover the expenses for holding the games in Tura and every penny was properly utilised for the conduct of the event.